The Tata Chemicals board meeting held on 29 March unequivocally praised the company chairman for the sterling role he had played as an institution builder of the Tata Group. In the meeting chaired by Seth, the vice chairman, Ratan, personally steered the resolutions heaping encomiums on Seth.

Ratan proposed that in 'recognition of Mr Seth's long and laudatory services to the Company for over half-a-century', he be named its chairman emeritus. The proposal was approved. Though Seth had 'declined' to accept any compensation for any formal advisory role he would play, Ratan ensured that a liberal retirement package befitting a man of his stature was approved.

To the outside world, it might have looked as if Seth was eased out. He faced a barrage of questions about whether the decision was forced on him. In an interview with a business newspaper, he stated: 'There is no question of any one forcing me to leave … In fact, Ratan pleaded with me [not to leave] … I have stepped down in the midst of cordial relations between Ratan and me and I was deeply touched by what the directors had to say about me at the board meeting.'

The Last of the Old Guard—Ajit Kerkar

By the middle of 1994, Ajit Baburao Kerkar was the only one of the old guard remaining in the Tata Group. During his thirty-seven years with the conglomerate, he had run the Taj group of hotels virtually singlehandedly.

Kerkar was working as a manager of a well-known British catering institution, Lyons Corner House, when he caught JRD's attention for his knowledge of the business and meteoric rise in the British hospitality industry. JRD persuaded Kerkar to join the Taj Mahal Palace, Bombay, whose standards had fallen over the years, as catering manager in 1962, with the understanding that he could operate the entire hotel if he managed to improve matters, which he did efficiently.

Kerkar soon became a legend in the hospitality industry. He transformed the poorly run Taj—which the Tatas had even considered selling to London's Ritz at one point—into a favourite haunt of the Bombay elite. While JRD had only envisaged transforming Taj Bombay, Kerkar ended up building the largest chain of hotels in India.